

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 8
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Truth Telling
26 July 2026



The Northern Coast of Songs
Akseli Gallen-Kallela, Finland, 1865-1931

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Lumière divine pour toute l'humanité
Composed and performed by Sabrina Tyas

Everything is Immanent – Jason Olshan
Air – Saginaw Rozzo

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Alleluyas – Simon Preston

Sienna Stribling, *2026 N.E.O. Organ Fellow*

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Meg Russett & Rev. Tanaka Pack

As we greet this new day together, we gather our love and courage,
because we can do hard things:

Brave things

Beautiful things

Risky and transformative things.

The Sacred always journeys with us
toward freedom:

For the sake of the collective life

For the sake of disrupting evil

For the sake of the human soul.

In this, our time and place:

We are called and accompanied.

We are never alone.

So, in this time set apart -
may our hearts be encouraged
for all that lies before us.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

[adpt/enfleshedmjadekaiser]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Gather Us In

Here in this place, the new light is streaming,
Shadows of doubt are vanished away.
See in this space our fears and our dreamings,
Brought here to you in the light of this day.
Gather us in, the lost and forsaken;
Gather us in; our spirits inflame.
Call to us now, and we shall awaken;
We shall arise at the sound of our name.

We are the young, our lives are a mystery;
We are the old, who yearn for your face.
We have been sung throughout all of history,
Called to be light to the whole human race.
Gather us in, the rich and the haughty;
Gather us in, the proud and the strong;
Give us a heart so meek and so lowly;
Give us the courage to enter the song.

Here we receive new life in the waters;
Here we receive the bread of new birth;
Here you shall call all of your children,
Call us anew to be salt for the earth.
Give us to drink the cup of compassion,
Give us to eat the bread that is you;
Nourish us well, and teach us to fashion
Lives that are holy and hearts that are true.

Not just in buildings, small and confining,
Not in some heaven light years away,
here in this place the new light is shining;
Now is God present, and now is the day.
Gather us in and hold us forever;
Gather us in and make us your own;
Gather us in, all peoples together,
Fire of love in our flesh and our bone.

***Prayer of Confession & Awareness**

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

God of freedom and liberation,
you have given us the laws of love, spoken through prophets,
and provided us with the Spirit to help guide us
in love and justice.
Still we struggle.

*The complexities of life and the challenges of
being human often win over.
In our pain, we do harm one another,
we do not intervene when our neighbors are targeted,
and we become possessive of power and resources.*

Yet you do not leave us where we are.
You call us to a new way of life and you ask us
to make your dream for this world a reality.

*Forgive us, O God, where we have failed
and surround us with your never ending love and hope,
as you ground our lives in mutual care and connection.*

*We pray this with gratitude for your love and grace and mercy.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

“Analogy of Being” part III
Laude

FAHAD SIADAT

***The Lord’s Prayer**

Meg Russett

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

When we become cognizant of the fact that our everyday
experiences and our gradual becoming
unfolds at a pace that can’t be corralled in by clock time,
then we can accept that slowing down and being present
with the season of life that we are flowing through,
is necessary.

Even the steps that seem unnecessary, become a part
of the sacred practice of loving where we are -
and we can find peace...in this moment and time.
[adpt/enfleshed]

This morning,
May the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Prophet Amos*
"But let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream!"

Meg Russett

This is the simple and complex wisdom of the ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of sleeping and waking,
in every state of our being, be near.

In our dreams, invite us to your creative vision of what could be:
of who we could become and what we could create together.
Nourish our imagination with glimpses of justice
that is full and healing that is rich.

In our waking up, may we do so with acceptance
of the day that closed, and embrace the day that is opening.
May your lovingkindness guide us in both accountability
to our friends, neighbors, and beloveds
and in grace that keeps us from being weighed down
by that which we can no longer control.

When we long to sleep but find ourselves awake
in the middle of the night, wrestling with the world,
our past, our future, or anxieties that do not yet
have names, may your Spirit of Peace embrace us.

When we struggle to stay awake - bone tired, soul heavy -
longing for the relief that is too far off, uphold us.

And then, O God, as we move through these cycles of rest and labor,
when they are balanced just right

and when they are all out of whack, be the constant
source that guides our life in peace, courage,
and the assurance of your hope for us.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"There Is Light"

CLARA MONIZ

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*"There is silence now where there once was colour There is light In place of fear There is space where life was full
and love replacing emptiness Hollow space overflowing The overflow and the flood Overflowing Love"*

~Clara Moniz

Sermon

Truth Telling

Rev. Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Prayer of Blessing

Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Meg Russett

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"I've Learned To Sing"

SAM SCHEIBE

N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*"I've learned to sing a song of hope, I've said goodbye to despair,
I caught the note in a thrush's throat, I sang---and the world was fair!
I've learned to sing a song of joy It bends the skies to me,
The song of joy is the song of hope Grown to maturity.
I've learned to laugh away my tears As through the dark I go
For love and laughter conquer fears My heart has come to know.
I've learned a song of happiness It is a song of love For love alone is happiness
And happiness is love." ~Georgia Douglass Johnson*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

*God of justice, your compassion and courage sustains us,
And your graciousness gives us hope.*

*Use us and these gifts to further your way
Of love, hope, and justice.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

For freedom,
Christ has set us free!
No longer bound by fear;
Not tempted towards
destruction!
Love is our salvation and
justice is our cause.
With the Spirit as our guide,
We shall not be moved.
-enfleshed

Choral Response

"Ka Sise Fun Iwenumo Emi Wa" YORUBA HYMN, arr. DAMILOLA ODEBIYI
N.E.O. Festival Choir and Cathedral Choir

*"In vanity we hope after worldly promises that vanish. Let us join together to bring about
the beloved community of the divine. God has promised the fruits of these labors. Amen!"*

***Hymn for the Journey**

Let Justice Like Water

ST DENIO

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

Pure wisdom and justice flow forth from your hand;
With you as our guide evil forces disband.
Give us, O Christ Jesus, the grace to prevail
O'er systems and powers that keep captives held.

O may we flow freely like waters and streams;
To heal and restore broken hearts and lost dreams.
Awaken us fully to all we can be,
Reclaiming our souls as we set people free.

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

[lyrics adapted from Jann Aldredge-Clanton]

Postlude

Improvisation

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music

The N.E.O. Voice Festival is here and with it, artists from around the world seeking the wonders of N.E.O.'s compassion-filled approach to the voice and creativity. The N.E.O. folks are all grateful to FCCLA for getting to be a part of this special community. Please join us on Wednesday 7/29 at 7:00 for Laurel's concert with Abe, and Friday 7/31 for the ExplOratorio premiere "At The End Of All Things" where we will present the concert-length piece we'll create this week. You can get a comp ticket at resonancecollective.org by using the code FCCLA.

The neuroscientist and author of "How Emotions Are Made," Lisa Feldman-Barrett, explains that scientists have shown since the 1970 that, functionally, truth is what we make it. That clear statement yields deep complexity, since we also feel truth as an essential and guiding principle in our lives. Today's music explores the growing edges of truth and how we come to understand and create with it. I've wanted to sing Fahad's "Analogy of Being" for years. Today we'll sing only the last movement. He found the text on a blackboard in a Pasadena church. It's an exploration of Thomas Aquinas, and it fits our theological space adroitly. He uses the concept of semantic satiation at the core of the music. Through repetition, the words begin to lose their meaning and we release into the wonder of their essence. Harmonically he floats a D in the sopranos over an Eb and C minor chord respectively giving the words "creator, sustainer, redeemer" and extra transformative power. Sam's setting of Georgia Douglass Johnson "I've Learned To Sing" wrestles at the heart of the truths we learn to tell ourselves. Douglass Johnson was a Harlem Renaissance playwright and poet who broke new ground as one of the first widely recognized women with this distinction. Sam's lilting, folk-inspired melody flows with the ease of the words. The poem reveals traumas behind its brightness. She explains how she chose to not let those traumas define her existence, but rather, found ways of defining life through truths that more accurately reflected the life she wanted to inhabit. The piece was originally written for younger voices, and Sam added some to the score for us making this a premiere performance. "Ka Sise Fun Iwenumo Emi" is a well known Nigerian hymn sung at celebrations as a community statement of faith and perseverance. Dami's setting that we sing this week will be a premiere performance. I am excited to welcome Dami into our space. We have premiered two of his choral/organ pieces in the past. His presence represents a perseverance of its own, and his determination to be physically present with this community, having been with us virtually from Nigeria many times. We'll only sing the last verse of his hymn setting today, and we'll premiere his newest work on Friday at the culmination of the N.E.O. Festival. Like his other pieces, "Ka Sise" rings with full timbral bliss. The Nigerian choral tradition has a long and glorious group singing history. I love listening into Dami's music to hear the sonorities embedded in his experience. Clara's "There Is Light" was the first choral piece she wrote. We are a coveted second performance. She uses sustained textures punctuated with text phrases to bring out the suspended, transformative energy of the text. She says of the piece that: "'There Is Light' was inspired by coming of age and leaving behind some of the irrational worries of childhood. It explores the

bittersweetness of losing the naivety that shapes a child's worldview while offering a hopeful look towards the future, as this innocence gives way to a deeper love and appreciation for those around you. The idea of 'light' present throughout the work represents love in many forms, the discovery of passions, and newfound freedom. The chords in the opening figure evoke the image of light rising over the horizon signaling new beginnings." When we let ourselves welcome truth as an essential, but complex element of our personal experience, we begin to realize how often we relearn its presence. Perhaps more importantly, we release ourselves from the dogmatic belief in one central truth, and allow our own experience to be one among a universe of realities.

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